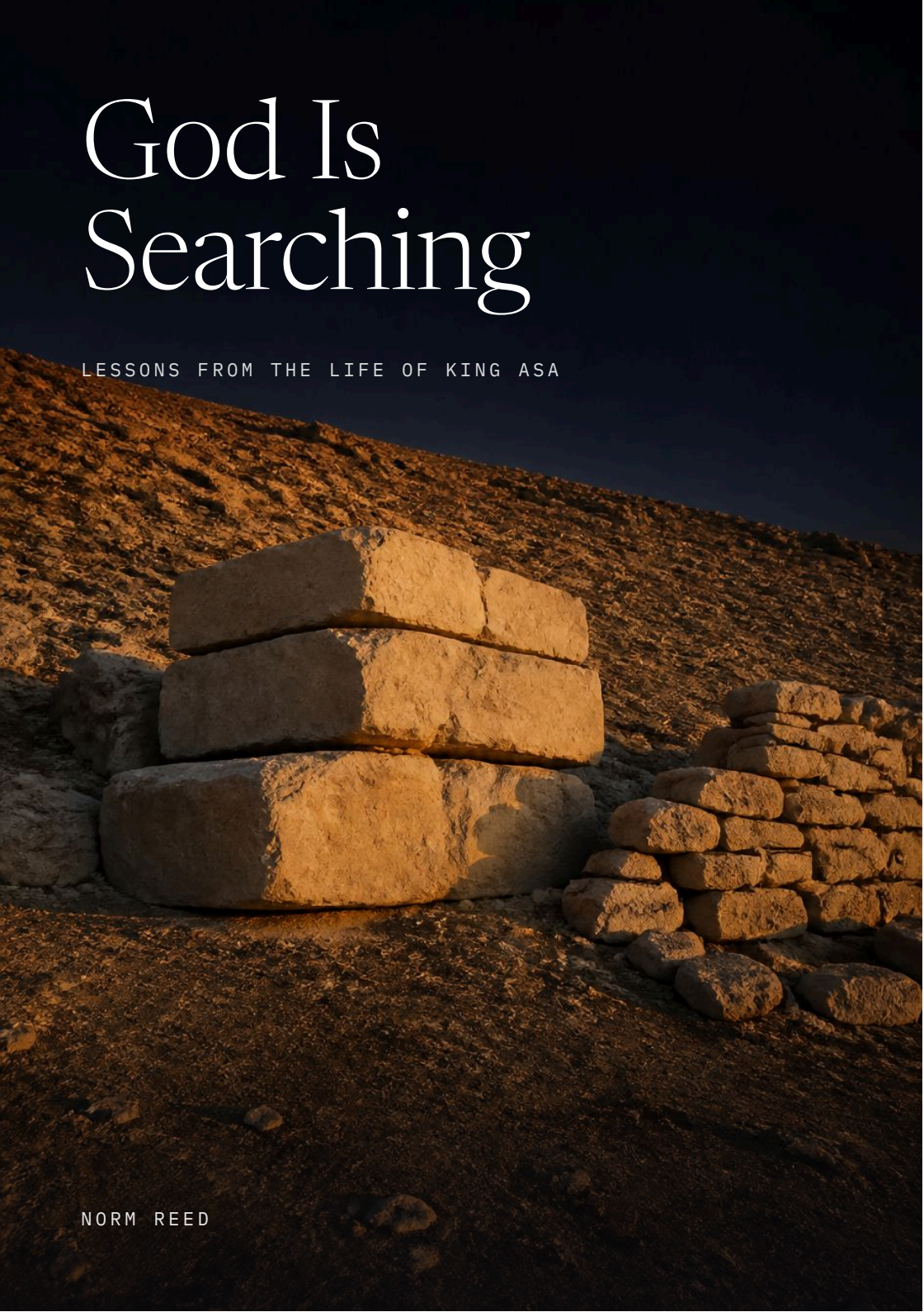
God Is Searching

LESSONS FROM THE LIFE OF KING ASA



NORM REED

God Is Searching

> *Lessons from the life of King Asa · 2 Chronicles 14–16*

One

NOT WRONG

I had a conversation this week with a friend who is a good deal younger than me and a better administrator than I was at his age.

He is in the middle of repairing something that was genuinely broken. He has the gift for it — he can see the shape of a problem, and he can see the structure that would answer it, and he has the patience to build the structure and make it work. Organisations are kept alive by people like him.

What he was describing was not a crisis. It was growth of a particular kind. The organisation has not got much bigger, but it has got a great deal more complicated. What is now required of it, by law and by regulation, is far beyond what any volunteer could carry. That means staff. Staff mean money. And money, in a body made up of many smaller bodies, means a contribution from each of them.

The arithmetic is sound. The structure is sound. Nobody is doing anything wrong, and the work genuinely has to be done.

But something that used to be carried by people who wanted to carry it is now a line in a budget that each of them pays.

I said to him that one of his biggest challenges would be to avoid creating administrative solutions that are too good.

I am not sure I explained it well. What I said was that I am not saying the decision is wrong – but that does not make it right. It works. It does not get to the heart of the thing. And it is missing something I could not name at the time.

I have been thinking about it since, and what I have been thinking about is a king called Asa.

Before you read on, do something with the text.

Open 2 Chronicles and find chapter 14, verse 8. Draw a line across the page underneath it. Everything above the line is introduction – who this man was and what he had built. Everything below it is the story, and the story happens twice.

That is how I was taught to read it.

Two

A GOOD KING

Asa's father was buried in the city of David, and the land had rest for ten years.

He did what was good and right in the eyes of the LORD his God. He took away the foreign altars and the high places. He broke down the pillars and cut down the Asherim. He went through the cities of Judah and took out the high places and the incense altars. It is carts and axes and men on ladders, and somebody had to organise it, town by town, until there was nothing left standing that should not have been.

And he commanded Judah to seek the LORD, the God of their fathers, and to keep the law and the

commandment.

So the kingdom had rest under him. No war in those years, for the LORD gave him peace.

Then he built.

He said to Judah: let us build these cities and surround them with walls and towers, gates and bars. The land is still ours, because we have sought the LORD our God. We have sought him, and he has given us peace on every side.

The walls went up as an act of thanksgiving. He named God as the reason he was able to build them. There is no gap between the rest he had been given and the use he made of it. The building programme is the proper response of a grateful man.

So they built and prospered.

He raised an army: three hundred thousand from Judah, armed with large shields and spears, and two hundred and eighty thousand men from Benjamin that carried shields and drew bows. All these were mighty men of valour.

That is the man. A reformer who finished the job, an administrator who used a decade of quiet to make his country defensible, and a king who said where the peace had come from.

And one more thing, which the Chronicler does not put here but at the end of the next chapter, as his verdict on the whole reign: the heart of Asa was wholly true all his days.

All his days.

Three

ZEPHATHAH

Zerah the Ethiopian came out against them with an army of a million men and 300 chariots, and came as far as Mareshah.

Asa went out to meet him.

He did not sit behind the walls. He had spent ten years of peace building fortified cities with towers and gates and bars, and when the thing those walls were built for finally arrived, he left them and marched. The two armies drew up their lines of battle in the Valley of Zephathah at Mareshah.

Five hundred and eighty thousand men, facing a million and three hundred chariots.

Then, with the lines drawn and the enemy in front of him, Asa cried to the LORD his God:

> *O LORD, there is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak. Help us, O LORD our God, for we rely on you, and in your name we have come against this multitude. O LORD, you are our God; let not man prevail against you.*

Three sentences. He begins with God's indifference to the numbers. He asks for help on the ground that they are relying on him and have come in his name. And then the last line, which is not a request at all.

Let not man prevail against you.

Not against us. Against you.

So the LORD defeated the Ethiopians before Asa and before Judah, and the Ethiopians fled. And Asa's army, which had not been dismissed, went after

them. They pursued as far as Gerar. They struck the cities round about, because the fear of the LORD was upon them, and there was much plunder in them. They carried away sheep in abundance, and camels.

Then they returned to Jerusalem.

He passed the first test by not being the one who solved it.

Four

AZARIAH

They came back from Gerar with sheep and camels, and a man was waiting for them.

The Spirit of God came upon Azariah the son of Oded, and he went out to meet Asa.

> *Hear me, Asa, and all Judah and Benjamin: The LORD is with you while you are with him. If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will forsake you.*

For a long time, he said, Israel was without the true God, without a teaching priest and without law. There was no peace to him who went out or to him who came in. Great disturbances afflicted all the

inhabitants of the lands. Nation was crushed by nation and city by city.

But when in their distress they turned to the LORD, the God of Israel, and sought him, he was found by them.

Take courage, Azariah said. Do not let your hands be weak, for your work shall be rewarded.

Asa took courage.

He went back through the land and put away the detestable idols from Judah and Benjamin, and from the cities he had taken in the hill country of Ephraim. He repaired the altar of the LORD that stood in front of the vestibule of the house of the LORD.

Then he called everybody in. Judah and Benjamin, and the people from Ephraim and Manasseh and

Simeon who had come over to him – and great numbers had deserted to him from Israel, because they saw that the LORD his God was with him. They gathered at Jerusalem in the third month of the fifteenth year of his reign.

They sacrificed seven hundred oxen and seven thousand sheep that day, out of the spoil they had brought back.

And they entered into a covenant to seek the LORD, the God of their fathers, with all their heart and with all their soul – and that whoever would not seek the LORD should be put to death, whether young or old, man or woman. They swore it with a loud voice, with shouting, with trumpets and with horns.

All Judah rejoiced over the oath, for they had sworn with all their heart and had sought him with their

whole desire. And he was found by them, and the LORD gave them rest all around.

Even Maacah his mother he removed from being queen mother, because she had made a detestable image for Asherah. He cut her image down, crushed it, and burned it at the brook Kidron.

The high places were not taken out of Israel. Nevertheless, the heart of Asa was wholly true all his days.

And he brought into the house of God the sacred gifts of his father and his own sacred gifts: silver, and gold, and vessels.

And there was no more war until the thirty-fifth year of the reign of Asa.

Five

RAMAH

For years there was no war.

Then, in the thirty-sixth year of his reign,[1] Baasha king of Israel came up against Judah and built Ramah, that he might permit no one to go out or come in to Asa king of Judah.

Ramah is five or six miles north of Jerusalem, on the road. Baasha did not besiege the capital or bring an army to the gates. He fortified a town astride the only way in and out and let the traffic stop. Nobody coming down to Jerusalem, nobody going up. No market, no pilgrims, no tribute, no men coming over from the north the way they had been coming over.

Asa took silver and gold out of the treasures of the house of the LORD and the king's house, and sent them to Ben-hadad king of Syria, who lived in Damascus:

> *There is a covenant between me and you, as there was between my father and your father. Behold, I am sending to you silver and gold. Go, break your covenant with Baasha king of Israel, that he may withdraw from me.*

Ben-hadad listened to King Asa. He sent the commanders of his armies against the cities of Israel, and they conquered Ijon, Dan, Abel-maim, and all the store cities of Naphtali.

Baasha heard about it, stopped building Ramah, and let his work cease.

Then Asa took all Judah up the road to the half-built town. They pulled it apart. They carried away the stones of Ramah and its timber — the dressed stone Baasha had quarried, the beams he had cut and hauled and squared — and with them Asa built Geba and Mizpah.

Two fortified towns of his own, north of Jerusalem, facing the way Baasha had come.

Six

IJON, DAN, ABEL-MAIM

The letter went north-east to Damascus. The armies came back the other way.

Ben-hadad sent the commanders of his armies against the cities of Israel, and they conquered Ijon, Dan, Abel-maim, and all the store cities of Naphtali.

These were towns in the far north, up where the hills run on into Lebanon. Dan was the old northern limit of the land, the place people meant when they said from Dan to Beersheba. The store cities of Naphtali held its supplies – grain, wine and oil.

They had done nothing to Asa. Ramah was a long way south of them.

They were not Syrians, either. They were Israelites: Baasha's subjects, and Abraham's children, from the same kingdom out of which great numbers had come over to Asa in the fifteenth year because they had heard that the LORD his God was with him.

They were also, until Asa wrote, under a treaty. Ben-hadad had a covenant with Baasha, and while it held, Ijon and Dan and Abel-maim were safe.

Go, break your covenant with Baasha king of Israel, that he may withdraw from me.

Baasha heard what was happening in the north and abandoned Ramah, which is what the letter was for. The towns were already taken.

The silver and gold came from the king's treasury and from the house of the LORD.

Earlier, Asa had carried the sacred gifts into that house — his father's and his own: silver, and gold, and vessels.

I am not saying the decision is wrong — but that does not make it right.

Seven

HANANI

At that time Hanani the seer came to Asa king of Judah.

Not later. Not when it had gone wrong. The stones of Ramah were being carted south and laid at Geba and Mizpah, and the seer walked in while the work was going well.

> *Because you relied on the king of Syria, and did not rely on the LORD your God, the army of the king of Syria has escaped you.*

Read the charge slowly, because it is not the one anybody expects.

Hanani does not say the plan failed. He says Ben-hadad got away. Syria had been in Asa's reach — a hostile power camped on his northern frontier, and the LORD could have given him that army too, the way he gave him Zerah's. Instead Asa paid him, and he went home with the silver and gold. The complaint is not that he lost. It is that he settled for winning.

Then Hanani reminds him of something he was present for.

> *Were not the Ethiopians and the Libyans a huge army with very many chariots and horsemen? Yet because you relied on the LORD, he gave them into your hand.*

Asa knew that. He had stood in the Valley of Zephathah with the lines drawn up and said it out loud: *we rely on you, and in your name we have come*

against this multitude. Hanani is not teaching him anything. He is quoting him to himself.

And then:

> *For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him. You have done foolishly in this, for from now on you will have wars.*

The last clause is the sentence.

He had no war in those years, because the LORD gave him peace. There was no more war until the thirty-fifth year. Years of quiet, in which he had built cities and gathered a nation and cut down his mother's idol at the Kidron.

From now on you will have wars.

Eight

THE EYES

For forty years this verse has been a pebble in my shoe.

I learned it in the older wording, and that is still the version that says itself in my head:

> *For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to shew himself strong in the behalf of them whose heart is perfect toward him.*

I have preached it many times. It is usually heard as an encouragement, and it is easy to preach that way — God is scanning the earth looking for somebody to back, so be the one he finds.

But that is not where the sentence sits. It sits in the middle of a rebuke, delivered by a man who has walked in while the building work is going well, and it is followed immediately by *you have done foolishly in this.*

Hanani is not offering him anything. He is telling him what he has just missed.

Two words in it are worth slowing down for.

The first is what God does. The older translation has *show himself strong*; the one I am using here has *give strong support*. The newer wording is probably closer to the plain sense. I prefer the old one, so I am wary of my own preference.

But the old wording catches something. Hanani is not describing help that arrives quietly while a man gets on with the job. He is describing God doing something people can see, and know who did it.

The second is the condition. *Perfect*, in the old wording; *blameless*, in the new. The Hebrew is *shalem* — whole, entire, all of a piece. It is not a word about flawlessness. A man with a *shalem* heart is not a man who has stopped sinning; he is a man who is not divided.

Which is where my trouble starts, because the Chronicler has already used that word about Asa. The heart of Asa was wholly true all his days.

All his days. Including this one. Including the year he sent the gold to Damascus, and the years after, when he had the prophet beaten and would not ask about his own feet.

I do not know what to do with that, and I have decided to stop pretending I do. Whatever a whole heart is, it is evidently not a guarantee. Asa had one, and still did this.

And then the first half of the verse, which I had been reading for thirty years as background.

The eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth.

God is the one searching. Not waiting to be approached, not sitting still until somebody prays — moving, continuously, over the whole earth, looking for a man he can be visibly strong for.

He found one. And the man he found had just fixed it so that God was not needed.

That is the sentence I have never got out of my shoe. Not *am I good enough for God to help*. Something worse, and much more my size:

Did I leave him anything to do?

Nine

FROM NOW ON

Asa got what he paid for. Baasha went home, the work at Ramah stopped, and the stones came south.

What he had also done was bring a Syrian army down into Israel.

Ben-hadad's commanders had now been into the northern hills. They had taken Ijon and Dan and Abel-maim and the store cities of Naphtali, and found them undefended and worth taking. They had learned that the king of Judah would pay silver and gold for a campaign, and that treaties in that part of the world could be bought out from under the people who were relying on them.

None of that stopped when Asa's problem was solved.

Hanani did not say *you will have a war.* He said: from now on you will have wars.

Asa was in Jerusalem through all of it.

He could walk out of the city and go north a few miles and see Geba and Mizpah standing, built out of Baasha's own dressed stone, exactly as he had planned.

He could see that part of it from the road.

He never saw Ijon, or Dan, or Abel-maim.

The complaint is not that he lost. It is that he settled for winning.

Ten

THE STOCKS

Then Asa was angry with the seer and put him in the stocks in prison, for he was in a rage with him because of this.

Earlier, another prophet had met him on a road.

Azariah had stopped him coming back from Gerar and told him plainly that God would be found by those who sought him and would forsake those who forsook him. That was not a comfortable message either. It came with a condition attached and a warning on the end of it.

As soon as Asa heard those words, he took courage. He went back through the land and tore out what

was left of the idols. He repaired the altar. He called the nation in and made them swear.

Same king. Same God. Two men sent to him, years apart.

The difference is not in the messages. Azariah's was harder, if anything – it put the whole future of the reign on a condition. Hanani only told him what he had just done.

The first one found a man who had been given a victory he had prayed for.

The second found a man who had arranged one himself.

Spurgeon puts it bluntly: "A bad man may do better than a good man on some one particular occasion."[2] Rehoboam did.

The rage did not stop at Hanani.

And Asa inflicted cruelties upon some of the people at the same time.

Eleven

FROM FIRST TO LAST

The acts of Asa, from first to last, are written in the Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel.

In the thirty-ninth year of his reign Asa was diseased in his feet, and his disease became severe.

He lived with it for the rest of his life.

> *Yet even in his disease he did not seek the LORD, but sought help from physicians.*

That is the word the whole story has been built on. He commanded Judah to seek the LORD. Azariah told him that if he sought him he would be found.

The nation swore a covenant to seek him with all their heart.

And here it is for the last time, with a *not* in front of it.

He sent for doctors instead. Spurgeon is careful about this, and so should we be: there is nothing wrong with sending for a doctor. "It is very wrong to send for physicians in place of crying to God."[3] The fault is not the physicians. It is the years he spent not asking.

And Asa slept with his fathers, dying in the forty-first year of his reign.

They buried him in the tomb that he had cut for himself in the city of David. They laid him on a bier that had been filled with various kinds of spices prepared by the perfumer's art, and they made a very great fire in his honour.

Twelve

TWO SCENES

Everything up to the end of chapter fourteen, verse eight, is introduction. After that the story is built twice.

Scene one. Zerah comes out of the south with a million men and three hundred chariots. Asa goes out, draws up his lines, and asks God to handle it. Zerah is destroyed. Azariah comes to Jerusalem with God's comment on what Asa has done: seek him and he will be found, forsake him and he will forsake you, take courage, your work shall be rewarded. And Asa answers the comment — he takes courage, tears out the idols, repairs the altar, and brings the nation into a covenant.

Scene two. Baasha comes out of the north and builds Ramah. Asa takes the silver and the gold and buys an army. Baasha withdraws. Hanani comes to Jerusalem with God's comment on what Asa has done: you relied on Syria and not on the LORD, you have done foolishly, from now on you will have wars. And Asa answers the comment – he puts Hanani in the stocks.

Four movements each. A threat, a response, a word from God about the response, and then what Asa did with that word.

The same king. Problems of the same kind, the second one smaller than the first. Two prophets, both telling him the truth to his face while the outcome was still fresh.

Only the second movement differs.

And the results are not ours to assign, because both prophets gave them out loud. *Your work shall be rewarded* — and the LORD gave them rest all around. *You have done foolishly in this, for from now on you will have wars.*

Rewarded and rest. Foolish and wars.

It is worth being careful about what Asa did right the first time, because it is not what we would expect to be praised for. He did not out-think Zerah. He drew up his lines, which any competent king would have done, and then handed the whole thing over. There is nothing in scene one to his credit as a strategist.

He passed the first test by not being the one who solved it.

Thirteen

AND SO DO I

Asa wanted to be a man who was whole-hearted toward God, and so do I.

Asa fixed problems for a living, and so do I.

That is not modesty in reverse. It is what I am. People bring me something broken and I do not experience it as a problem; my mind goes straight to the shape of the answer, to what could be pulled together and how. Other people see the mess. I see the fix. I have been doing it for forty years and I am good at it, and organisations need men and women who are.

Asa had it too. Read the first eight verses again — a decade of peace spent fortifying town after town, walls and towers and gates and bars, and an army of five hundred and eighty thousand raised and equipped. That is not piety. That is an administrator with a clear run and good weather.

And he did it in thanksgiving. *The land is still ours, because we have sought the LORD our God.* He said so out loud while the walls were going up.

Then later he did the same kind of thing again — saw a problem, found an answer, executed it cleanly — and it was the worst decision of his life.

Nothing about the gift had changed. Nothing about his competence had failed. The second solution was, if anything, more elegant than the first.

I have not come through forty years of this without doing damage. I have had plenty of good ideas that

turned out not to be God's ideas. I missed the mark. People got hurt. Often the problem I was fixing got worse.

What changed was the last fifteen, leading a church, where the consequences of what I decide come back to me and stay with me. That is when I started working at this properly. Not because I became wiser. Because I was the one who had to live in the building afterwards.

What I learned, slowly, was to live with a decision before enacting it.

Sometimes the people around me applied the brakes. Sometimes I was awake enough to recognise that God was saying wait.

And when I waited, the problem did not usually disappear. What changed was what it was. It stopped being an obstacle and became a way through — into

something God had in mind for the church that I had not thought of.

And the work is not what I expected it to be. It is not *will this work*. My solutions usually work; that was never the question, and it was not the question at Ramah either.

It is: **is this God?**

Fourteen

WAIT

I built a failsafe in.

Not early, and not always. But in the later years it has taken the form of a team of men and women around me who will tell me when they think an idea of mine may not be God.

They do not tell me I am wrong. They rarely tell me the idea is bad — usually it isn't, and they can see that as well as I can. What they say is that the idea is good, and workable, and may not be God. And their suggestion is almost never to throw it out.

It is to wait.

That is much harder to receive than a rebuke, and it took me a long time to work out why.

A rebuke has a shape. You did a wrong thing, you own it, you put it right, and it is finished. There is something to do, and I am good at doing things.

Wait has no shape at all. There is nothing to confess, because nothing has happened. There is nothing to fix, because the plan is sound. There is nothing to execute, nothing to delegate, nothing to schedule. The only instruction is to stand still holding a good idea, and for a man whose entire aptitude is for moving things forward, that is the one instruction with no handhold on it.

It is also, as nearly as I can tell, exactly what Hanani said.

He did not accuse Asa of some general backsliding. He did not call him a bad king. He pointed at one

specific, successful, recently completed decision and said: this one was not God. And Asa, who had torn down his own mother's idol at the Kidron rather than let it stand, could not take it.

He put the man in the stocks.

I have never put anyone in the stocks.

I have wanted to.

Fifteen

WHAT RISES

When somebody says wait, something in me pushes back. Every time.

It is almost never visible. I say thank you. I say that is a fair point, let me sit with it, and I mean the words while I am saying them. Outwardly I am a man receiving counsel well, and for a long time I thought that was the whole transaction.

It isn't. Underneath the thank-you there is something pushing back, and it is still there an hour later when I am driving home.

That reaction is the most useful instrument I have.

If my objection were to their reasoning, I would argue their reasoning — out loud, in the room, which is what we are all there for. I never do. The pushback does not engage with what they said at all. It does not produce a counter-argument. It just sits there, resisting.

Which means it is not about the idea. It is about me, and about what waiting is doing to me.

So I have learned to stop and look at it instead of driving through it. Not to ask whether they are right — that usually takes care of itself. To ask what it is about waiting that I cannot stand.

The answer is different each time.

Asa had the same reaction. The Chronicler names it: he was angry with the seer, and he was in a rage with him because of this.

He acted on it. A man went into the stocks, and other people were hurt.

Sixteen

THE VILLAGE

In 2019 I went to Texas to look at a village built for people who were homeless. I had seen it on video, I had looked at what we had, and I went to learn the model so that we could do it here.

It was a good model. I could see how it would work in Tasmania, and I could see how to build it. I was ready to put it to the church as vision.

Two things happened at about the same time. I came to see that the problem in front of us was not houses but community, and those are not the same problem. And my leadership team suggested I hold off for a while.

So I did, and nothing happened. There was no clarity, no door closing, nothing to point at.

Then my heart stopped, and in the time afterwards I saw what I had nearly done. Had I gone ahead, I would have committed this church — and whoever came after me — to an administrative load that could have taken thirty years to carry. He would have inherited it from me without ever being asked.

The village was a good idea. It was not our idea to have.

Seventeen

THE PLANE

Years ago in Papua New Guinea I organised a national conference for our movement, in a village in Northern Province that was a long way from anything. I chartered three or four aircraft to bring the delegates into a remote airstrip, and from the airstrip it was a good hour's walk to the village.

It worked. It was also expensive, and I knew while it was happening that we would not be able to do it again.

The thought came to me more than once that what we needed was an aeroplane of our own. I also knew that the mechanics of getting one were well beyond me.

Then one afternoon I was sitting at a table with Barry, our field director, and a visiting speaker, who said we could do with an aircraft. Barry reached across the table, took her hand, and said, "I agree with you about that."

That was very nearly the whole conversation. I can still see it.

Back in Moresby we looked into what sort of plane it would be and what it would cost and whether we could ever pay for it. *Tell him he's dreaming* would have been an understatement.

A few weeks later the visiting speaker rang from Australia. They had raised the money. How much did we need?

Then finding an aircraft became a nightmare, and stayed one, until a former missionary we had not been in contact with rang out of the blue. He owned

a plane, he was returning to Australia, and he wanted to sell it at cost.

So we had an aeroplane and we had the money, and nobody to fly it.

Some time after that Barry was preaching in Australia, and a couple came up to him afterwards and said they believed God was calling them to Papua New Guinea. He had said nothing about the plane, and nothing about needing a pilot. He asked what they did. The answer, almost in passing, was a commercial pilot's licence.

Asa could stand on the road north of Jerusalem and look at Geba and Mizpah, and every stone in them had been carried there because he wrote a letter.

I have arranged a great many things in forty years. I did not arrange that.

Eighteen

STILL SEARCHING

By now you will want a way of telling.

Something you could apply. A question to run a decision through, a checklist, three marks of a God idea and three marks of a good one. I have wanted that for forty years and I do not have it. I have come to think it is better that I don't.

If I gave you a test, you would be good at it. You would learn it quickly, apply it rigorously, and pass. And then the test would be the thing you relied on, and you would have built a better machine and still not have asked God.

Waiting can go the same way. A man can make a discipline out of waiting — thirty days on every major decision, a standing agenda item, a proper process — and at the end of it be exactly where Asa was, holding a sound plan he arrived at by himself.

What Asa did at the end was not dramatic.

He did not renounce anything. He did not set up an idol or burn incense on a high place or take a foreign wife. He had torn down his own mother's image at the Kidron, and nothing like that came back. There is no scene, no moment, no confrontation at the end.

He just stopped asking.

His feet were in agony and he sent for physicians and did not once send for God. And nothing in his circumstances told him anything was wrong. Geba and Mizpah were still standing. The walls he had

built in the quiet years were still standing. The nation was intact. When he died they laid him on a bier filled with spices prepared by the perfumer's art, and they made a very great fire in his honour, and as far as I can tell everybody at that funeral thought well of him.

The whole time, the eyes of the LORD were running to and fro throughout the whole earth.

They had never stopped. They were going over Jerusalem while he sat with his feet up and the doctors came and went. He was not hidden from them, and he was not out of reach of them. He had nothing he needed them for.

So I am not going to give you a method. I am going to give you the question I have carried for forty years, and you can do what you like with it.

Did you leave him anything to do?

Scripture quotations are from the ESV unless marked otherwise. 2 Chronicles 16:9 is quoted once in the King James Version, as marked.

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1 The Chronicler dates this to the thirty-sixth year of Asa's reign. Kings puts Baasha's death about ten years before that (1 Kings 15:33; 16:8), so the figure cannot be read straight. Keil and Delitzsch take it as a copyist's slip for the sixteenth year; Jamieson-Fausset-Brown reckon it from the division of the kingdom and arrive at much the same place. On the plain reading, the two scenes in this book stand twenty years apart. On the usual emendation, about one — roughly a year after the covenant, the trumpets, and the burning of his mother's idol at the Kidron. I have kept the Chronicler's numbers in the text. The second reading is the harder of the two to live with.

2 C. H. Spurgeon, *A Lesson from the Life of King Asa*, Metropolitan Tabernacle Pulpit no. 1,152, vol. 20 (1874).

3 Spurgeon, *A Lesson from the Life of King Asa*.

This book did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.